# Blue

## By Michel Magee

*(Becky is tidying the child's toys. She hums "You Are my Sunshine" while she works. She picks up a blue ball and hugs it to herself. She closes her eyes for a moment and smiles)*

## INTRODUCTION

*Most new mothers anticipate the birth of their child will be one of the best days of their lives. Unfortunately, this isn't always the case. We live in a 1st world country where nearly *1 in 10 babies still takes their first breath too soon. And behind every tiny incubator lies a world of hope, fear, and quiet resilience -- a mother's whispered prayers competing with the steady hum of hospital machines. (sing 1st line(s) from **You are My Sunshine)*

*This selection gives voice to the journey of these women: the sleepless nights, the fragile beginnings, and the unshakable love that binds a mother to her child even when that tiny being doesn't survive.*

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**BECKY: (Pg 68-71)** *(in a straightforward manner)* Right off I named her Blue seein' as she was born on the first night of the Blue Moon 'n all and bein' so little – shy a' three pounds, downright puny – cause a' comin' almost three months early 'n I didn't want her to go off havin' no name when they come for her by ambulance for the ride up to the hospital in Jeff City, right after Mama Linny and me baptized her and held hands and recited the Lord's Prayer with Nurse Carter aleadin', who is, I'll have you know, a direct descendant of Mother Maybelle herself. Doc Rhoads joined in for the "Amen!" *(pause)* Then . . . Blue was gone.

*(walks over to the porch steps, settles herself, and begins to snap string beans)* When I recollect that night, I can still hear the siren wailin' down the highway with my baby, long past the distance an ear can take in sound for sure. Mama Linny, who is, for your information, my aunt what raised me up when my own good mama died birthin' me, says that kind of distance ain't measured in miles 'cause the heart don't know nothin' 'bout miles.

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*(pauses, snapping the string beans, as though considering her next comment, perhaps for the first time)* Hearts don't know nothin' 'bout speed either, if y'all's to ask me. It all a' got to goin' so ***fast***. But when I play it over in my heart, that night moves like one a' them slowed down commercials for face soap or ice tea. *(pause)* However, the truth be known here, Blue started a makin' her UN-hesitatin' way into this world less'n two hours after I had ice cream with her daddy at the Tastee Top, just off the four-lane over by Bender's Dry Goods, where, by the way, I'd already started puttin' her layette away on lay away, in yella 'n white mostely, seein' as I didn't know if she was gonna turn out a boy or a girl. *(pause)* Ray – that's Blue's daddy – dropped me off to home early. We was in the very middle of another set-to over getting' married, but the ice cream – or maybe it was the marshmalla butter-nutter toppin' – had me feelin' outta favor with my innards, so I let go a' my haranguin' and then sure 'nough, I started in with cramps ' n all and Mama Linny said she didn't feel it was a plain ol' bellyache from too much indulgence and we'd est call Doc Rhoads. And the rest y'all know.

*(resumes snapping beans, shifting her position occasionally)* Naturally right off, I called the hospital long distance up in Jeff City to inquire how Blue was getting' on. The nurse said fine, and I said, well, if she's fine, then why's she there? *(Forcefully, in an I'm nobody's fool manner)* I didn't much care for the sassy answer she give back, so I packed my bag and never mind that I was practically ***bleedin'*** to death. I called Ray right now and told him he was a daddy – ready or not – and that he'd better do right by me and Blue and drive me up to where they was keepin' her and I wasn't takin' no for no answer, 'n ***that*** was ***that***.

*(snapping the bean she is holding with ferocity)* ***Well!*** Let me tell y'all . . . it's a good thing that child had her mama at hand, 'cause y'all never seen nothin' like it. When I got there they had tubes stickin' outta her pitiful little body and an IV needle in her head! *(without a hint of condescension)* IV is for intravenous, I'll have you know. *(tenderly)* Poor sweet Blue. Her little red baby arms weren't no bigger 'n my thumb. Veins too small. Thin as a ***hayer*** a nurse explained to me, so that's why they done it to her head where the veins is bigger. *(turns to bring the laundry basket closer. Facing the audience, she drifts forward, absently*

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*touching the clothes still hanging on the line as she moves)* 'Bout mid-point in our ordeal, I also had me a serious talk with Blue. Not the out loud kind . . . the kind you have in your head 'n the folks you're close with pick up on. Now y'all take for instance my ol' Uncle Sonny. He's got Alzheimer's 'n things mixed up but ***good***. *(pause)* He'll say: "The WALLS is on fire! . . . and ***who'r*** you?" *(with patience and sincerity)* And I'll say the walls ain't on fire, ol' honey . . . 'n I'm ***Becky***, same as you been seein' ever' day a' my life. *(pause)* Holdin' a conversation with Uncle Sonny can wear a body thin. *(pause)* But the point I was makin' was there's time we'll be a'settin' quiet like . . . and I'll be spinnin' in my own mind 'bout tryin' one a' them new hybrid okras and Uncle Sonny'll come back from his private wild blue younder and say, "Yessum, okra'd be right fine" . . . Like he was plugged into my head.

I plugged into Blue's head that very same way . . . and I got a sad, floatin' feelin' like Blue didn't know where she was s'posed to be. Had things gone accordin' to plan, she'd a' been safe and sound right inside me. But things didn't go accordin' to plan – and here was my child, little as she was, weighin' this mighty decision 'tween choosin' Earth or what surely would be Heaven. So I said . . .

*(The break with the present occurs here, as she drifts center stage. The lighting dims until Becky is spotlit on a darkened stage. Her hands are held to indicate they are resting on either side of an incubator. She begins this passage as though speaking through her heart to Blue – slowly, and with great tenderness)*

**BECKY:** Listen here, Little Lady . . . this here is your Mama a'talkin' . . . You got to get better . . . and bigger. There's a fine land outside these walls, Blue . . . and a lake so wide you'll think it'll never end . . . And at night . . . there's stars . . . 'bout a forever's worth . . . One of 'em shinin' just for you. It's home . . . *(pause)* I know your early comin' was a surprise to you 'n me both, but there's such a thing as nice surprises. Just wait 'til you see all them pretty things I got put on layaway for you . . . *(long pause)* Blue, honey . . . I need to hold you . . . and I can't if you gonna stay hangin' out on that ventilator, hole-up in your little Plexiglas box. Holdin's real good, Blue. 'Member that time . . . couple days back . . . I got to hold you seven . . . whole . . . minutes. *(smiling, with tears about to spill)* They was the best seven minutes a' my life, Blue.

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*(in pantomime, Becky opens an imaginary incubator and lifts out her baby. She cradles Blue in her arms. Her voice is barely above a whisper as she begins to croon)* You are my sunshine . . . my only sunshine . . . you make me happy . . . when skies are gray . . . You'll never know dear . . . How much I love you . . . *(her voice breaks. Her expression is one of anguish as she looks up as though both pleading and praying)* Please . . . oh, please, don't take my sunshine away. . .

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Michel Magee***
***Book: Monologues for Women by Women, Pgs 68-71***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2001 National Qualifier***
***2004 National Qualifier***
***2006 National Qualifier***
***2008 National Qualifier***
***2010 National Qualifier***
***2020 National Qualifier – MS***
***2022 National Qualifier – MS***
***2024 National Qualifier***
***NIETOC***
***IL State Qualifier***
***KS State Qualifier***
***MN State Qualifier***
***OH State Qualifier***

**** Introduction Statistic Source***
*https://www.cdc.gov/maternal-infant-health/preterm-birth/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com*

********You are my Sunshine – Music and Lyrics*
*https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rc2jsjnt-HY*

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